CHAPTER 4 The Tool: Inner Authority The Higher Force: The Force of Self-Expression

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Subject	**CHAPTER 4 The Tool: Inner Authority The Higher Force: The Force of Self-Expression**
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Internal

Everyone has moments like this; you want to make a good impression but your brain and body betray you. We call these moments of "freezing." Symptoms were typical—dry mouth, shakiness, and "brain lock," an inability to remember information or even form coherent sentences. Sometimes people lose an accurate sense of their bodies, accidentally spilling or bumping into things. Moments of freezing can range from mild, in which the person feels an uncomfortable stiffness, to extreme, in which the person literally can't move or speak, the proverbial deer caught in headlights.

It's also common to think that we freeze because of the situation we're in—meeting an intimidating person or speaking to a large group. But freezing is actually caused by an inner insecurity; an insecurity you may not even be aware of until you suddenly lose your ability to express yourself.

Let's see how this works in your life:

Close your eyes and imagine yourself in front of a person or group who makes you feel insecure. Focus on your body. Identify any of the symptoms of freezing we've mentioned. What is it like to try to express yourself in the face of these symptoms?

If you're like most people, it is awkward and uncomfortable. But a little awkwardness wouldn't matter if it were the only price you paid for insecurity. Unfortunately, it costs a lot more than that.

THE PRICE OF INSECURITY

Insecurity destroys people's ability to connect with one another. Over time, insecurity makes you stiff and uninteresting to other people, and, paradoxically, it also makes you ungiving. Insecure people are so obsessed with how others perceive them that they give almost nothing of themselves. As a result, they feel even more alienated.

Connecting to others is also an essential ingredient in success. The most important opportunities in life come from other people. It would be nice if they granted those opportunities based on merit; a reward for talent or hard work. But that's not the way the world works. *People give you opportunities because they feel connected to you*.

Why is insecurity so difficult to get rid of?

The answer will seem very strange at first. Inside each of us is a *second self*, a living being we're deeply ashamed of. No matter how hard you try, you can never get rid of this second self.

THE SHADOW

The idea of a second self living inside you may seem unbelievable. Keep an open mind and follow what happened to Jennifer.

The "Shadow" is everything we don't want to be but fear we are, represented in a single image. It's called the Shadow because it follows us wherever we go.

The great Swiss psychiatrist Carl Jung was the first to say that everyone has a Shadow regardless of their accomplishments, talents, or appearance. The Shadow is one of many "archetypes" we're born with. An archetype is a patterned way of perceiving the world. For example, everyone is born with a sense of what a mother should be like. Jung would call this the "archetypal" mother. This is an archetype, not to be confused with your real, biological mother. However, this archetype does shape what you expect from your real mother. There are many archetypes—Mother, Father, God, the Devil, to name a few—and each has a profound effect on how you experience the world.

There's a way in which the Shadow is different from all the other archetypes: the others affect how you see the world; *the Shadow determines how you see yourself*. Now you can understand why insecurity is so hard to get rid of. You can eliminate a specific flat but you can't eliminate the Shadow itself. It's part of being human.

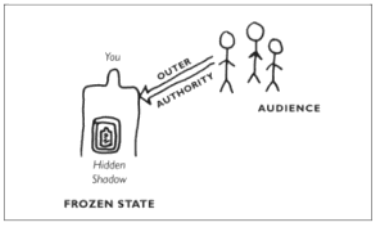
Let's see what your Shadow looks like.

Go back to the feeling you had in the last exercise: you're in front of a group of people who make you feel insecure and self-conscious. Focus on the emotions this brings up. Now push those feelings out in front of you and imagine they form a being with a face and body.

You've just seen your Shadow. Make a careful note of what it looks like. Don't worry if you have the "right" image; there isn't one. Everyone's Shadow looks different. But no matter what it looks like, its appearance is unsettling: the handsome ladies' man whose Shadow looked like a lumbering troll; the female CEO of a Fortune 500 company whose Shadow looked like a lonely, weeping eight-year-old girl. It might be unlikable, ugly, or stupid. As you work with it, its appearance may change. The Shadow is the source of one of the most basic human conflicts. Everyone wants to feel that as an individual we have value. But when we look inside ourselves, we see the Shadow and we're ashamed. Our immediate reaction is to turn away—to look *outside* ourselves for some evidence of our worth. This takes the form of looking to others for approval and validation.

The problem is, no amount of approval from others can make you feel worthy—because no amount of validation can eliminate your Shadow. Anytime you're alone and you turn inward—there's your Shadow, making you feel embarrassed and inferior.

The picture below shows how this works.



The picture diagrams the state of affairs in someone prone to freezing (which is almost everyone). The person is ashamed of his Shadow and does everything possible to keep it hidden inside him. This is illustrated by the box around the shaded figure labeled "Hidden Shadow." The audience figures in the upper right are big because the person experiences them as having the power to define his value. This power comes at him through the arrows labeled "Outer Authority." Since he's hiding his Shadow, the external force causes him to freeze.

As the picture makes clear, looking outward doesn't work any better than looking inward; either way, a real sense of self-worth tends to elude us.

THE HIGHER FORCE: SELF-EXPRESSION

Watch little kids, particularly when they're playing. They aren't self-conscious or insecure. They express themselves freely and exuberantly. *They almost never freeze*. The reason they don't is that they're filled with a higher force called the "Force of Self-Expression." It has a magical quality: it drives us to reveal ourselves in a truthful, genuine way—without caring at all how other people react. As a consequence, when you're connected to this force, you speak with unusual intensity and clarity. Everyone has experienced this force at some point in their adult lives—maybe in an excited discussion about something that's personally meaningful, maybe when you're comforting a friend in a crisis, even when you're making up a bedtime story for your kids. In each instance and a thousand others, you've lost yourself in the experience and allowed the Force of Self-Expression to speak through you. You've become a conduit for something wiser and more fluent than your normal self. There's relief and joy in this.

THE TOOL: INNER AUTHORITY

There's one big difference between this tool and the two you've already learned. The Reversal of Desire and Active Love evoke higher forces that are independent of the obstacles they overcome.

But in the tool you're about to learn, the higher force comes from the obstacle itself. The tool turns the Shadow into a conduit for a higher force—the Force of Self-Expression.
The tool is called "Inner Authority." This means just what it says. It's not an authority that comes from the approval of any one outside you; it's the authority you can get only when you're speaking from your inner self.

In order to use Inner Authority, you need to be able to see an image of your Shadow. You've already seen it once; in the section on the Shadow, you projected your insecure feelings out in front of you until they formed a being you could see. Try doing the same thing again. Don't worry about getting the "right" image; it will continue evolving anyway. What's most important is that you feel a real presence in front of you. Practice conjuring up the Shadow until it becomes easy.

You're going to learn the tool by using an imaginary audience. It doesn't matter if it's an audience of one or a group; it doesn't matter if they're strangers or people you know. The only thing that matters is that it's an audience you feel insecure about addressing. You're going to use the tool to unfreeze yourself because you have something to express.

Inner Authority

Imagine that you're standing in front of an audience of one or many. See an image of your Shadow off to one side, facing you. Ignore the audience completely and focus all of your attention on the Shadow. Feel an unbreakable bond between the two of you—as a unit you're fearless.

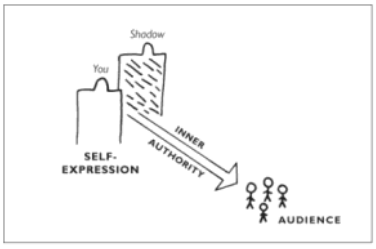
Together, you and the Shadow forcefully turn toward the audience and silently command them to "LISTEN!" Feel the authority that comes when you and your Shadow speak with one voice.

Once you've used the tool, it should feel like you've cleared a space where you're free to express yourself. All you have to do is stay focused on the connection to the Shadow. If you don't feel freed up, repeat the tool until it creates a sense of flow.

The tool consists of three steps: projecting the Shadow image, feeling a bond with it, and then silently commanding them to listen as you turn to face the audience. Practice these steps until you can move through them quickly. You want the steps to become second nature, so that you can use them in front of people, even while you're speaking.

As you practice the tool and call up the Shadow, its appearance may change. That's not a bad thing. Like anything else that's alive, the Shadow evolves. What's most important is that its presence forms an unbreakable bond you can feel.

The picture below shows how Inner Authority works.



The person in the picture has brought the Shadow out of hiding. It's now outside the person and bonded with him. Speaking with one voice, they evoke the Force of Self-Expression. This higher force gives the person inner authority, indicated by the arrow moving out toward the audience. The figures representing the audience are small and below the person—they're no longer a threat.

The expressive power of the inner self is released through this bond with the Shadow. Once you become an advanced practitioner of the tool, you'll be able to express yourself freely in situations that you would've frozen in previously.

WHEN TO USE INNER AUTHORITY

Inner Authority should be used any time you feel the pressure to perform. This is much more common than you think if you define a *performance* as any situation where you're subject to the judgments and reactions of others. This could take the form of a job interview, sales meeting, presentation, or an awkward social situation such as a blind date or big party. Calling such instances performances doesn't mean you have to put on an act. In fact, the goal is not to try to gain the approval of the audience. Rather, you use the tool to overcome that pressure and express yourself freely.

Inner Authority will not work if you wait for a "big" event—such as speaking before hundreds of people—to use it for the first time. These events are so intimidating that you'll freeze unless you work up to them. If you practice the tool when you're alone, doing it again and again until it feels like second nature, you'll soon be ready to try it in front of people. Start by using the tool when you're around someone who *doesn't* make you anxious—a family member, a coworker, your best friend, or your spouse. Most of us feel some need for acceptance even around these people. Now you're ready to tackle situations that cause you anxiety. You might be facing a confrontation or a request for help that you feel uncomfortable making. Push yourself into these situations intentionally and use Inner Authority right in the middle of them. The more you do this, the less intimidated you'll feel. Once you make Inner Authority a natural part of your daily life, you can start to use it for big events, such as important public speeches. When you use Inner Authority during these intimidating occasions, something amazing will happen: you'll start to look forward to some of them—not because they're stress-free, but because you'll feel excitement at the prospect of expressing yourself.

THE SECRET BENEFITS OF SELF-EXPRESSION

As we said, the Force of Self-Expression comes through your Shadow. But there's something wonderful about this higher force: *It speaks through you in a way that is unique to you*. It gives each of us a distinctive voice—and yet all our voices derive from the same ultimate source. That's why true self-expression feels like it's coming from someplace else—and simultaneously makes you more yourself. In fact, the ancients saw self-expression as the fundamental quality of the universe. In Genesis, God is portrayed as a self-expressive being. God *says* let there be light, and light is created. God *says* let the earth bring forth plants and trees, and it does.

OTHER USES OF INNER AUTHORITY

Inner Authority lets you overcome initial shyness, particularly around people you're interested in romantically.
Inner Authority lets you express need and vulnerability.
Inner Authority allows you to connect to your loved ones with more emotion.
Inner Authority activates a higher force in the act of writing, not just speaking.

SUMMARY OF INNER AUTHORITY

What the Tool Is For

In intimidating situations, when you find it difficult to express yourself or even connect with other people. These are moments when you "freeze," become wooden or stiff, unable to express yourself in a natural, spontaneous way. Underlying this is an irrational sense of insecurity. The tool allows you to overcome the insecurity and be yourself.

What You're Fighting Against

Insecurity is a universal but badly misunderstood human trait. We think we know what's making us insecure—our appearance, level of education, or socio-economic status. In fact, there's something deep inside us that is the cause of all insecurity. It's called the Shadow—the embodiment of all our negative traits—and we're terrified that someone will see it. As a consequence, we expend a lot of energy hiding it, which makes it impossible for us to be ourselves. The tool gives us a new way to deal with the problem of having a Shadow.

Cues to Use the Tool

1. Whenever you feel performance anxiety. This could be triggered by social events, confrontations, speaking in public.
2. Use the tool right before the event as well as during it.
3. A less-obvious cue would be when you're anticipating the event and worrying about it.

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The Tool in Brief

1. Standing in front of any kind of audience, see your Shadow off to one side, facing you. (It works just as well with an imaginary audience or an audience composed of only one person.) Ignore the audience completely and focus all of your attention on the Shadow. Feel an unbreakable bond between the two of you—as a unit you're fearless.
2. Together, you and the Shadow forcefully turn toward the audience and silently command them to "LISTEN!" Feel the authority that comes when you and your Shadow speak with one voice.

The Higher Force You're Using

The Force of Self-Expression allows us to reveal ourselves in a truthful, genuine way—without caring about others' approval. It speaks through us with unusual clarity and authority, but it also expresses itself nonverbally, like when an athlete is "in the zone." In adults, this force gets buried in the Shadow. The tool, by connecting you to the Shadow, enables you to resurrect the force and have it flow through you.